Title: Eight Individuals Plead to Roles in $11 Million Bank Fraud Conspiracy
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TRENTON, N.J. – Eight defendants admitted to their roles in a conspiracy to defraud banks by depositing stolen checks and withdrawing the funds, U.S. Attorney Robert Frazer announced.

The following individuals each pleaded guilty before U.S. District Judge Michael A. Shipp in Trenton federal court to a one-count Information charging them with conspiracy to commit bank fraud:

Britany Brown, 39, of Philadelphia, Pennsylvania, pleaded guilty on July 21, 2026. Sentencing is scheduled for December 8, 2026.

Clarence Semmon, 42, of Trenton, New Jersey, pleaded guilty on July 21, 2026. Sentencing is scheduled for December 9, 2026.

Joseph Graves-Carmichael, 43, of Trenton, New Jersey, pleaded guilty on July 22, 2026. Sentencing is scheduled for December 9, 2026.

Andrew Hooper, 38, of New Brunswick, New Jersey, pleaded guilty on July 22, 2026. Sentencing is scheduled for December 7, 2026.

Thomas Lee, 56, of Beverly, New Jersey, pleaded guilty on July 22, 2026. Sentencing is scheduled for December 16, 2026.

Patricia Kearse, 47, of Philadelphia, Pennsylvania, pleaded guilty on July 22, 2026. Sentencing is scheduled for December 7, 2026.

Shabazz Rouzard, 34, of Ewing, New Jersey, pleaded guilty on July 22, 2026. Sentencing is scheduled for December 16, 2026.

John Gerard Ebert, 42, of Hamilton, New Jersey, pleaded guilty on August 4, 2026. Sentencing is scheduled for December 17, 2026.

According to documents filed in this case and statements made in court:

From March 2023 through June 2025, the Defendants conspired to deposit stolen checks—including U.S. Department of Treasury checks—at various banks in New Jersey and Pennsylvania. The conspirators impersonated the businesses or individuals listed as payees on the stolen checks, often by acquiring business documents in the names of the payees. Once the conspirators acquired fraudulent business documents or opened fraudulent bank accounts, they deposited the stolen checks and split the proceeds. In total, the conspirators deposited or attempted to deposit over 100 Treasury and commercial checks totaling over $11 million. Many of the Treasury checks were refunds issued as Employee Retention Credits, a program the Internal Revenue Service created during the COVID-19 pandemic to encourage businesses to retain employees.

The bank fraud conspiracy charge is punishable by a maximum potential penalty of 30 years in prison and also carries a fine of up to $1,000,000, twice the gross amount of any pecuniary gain that any persons derived from the offense, or twice the gross amount of any pecuniary loss sustained by any victims of the offense.

U.S. Attorney Frazer credited special agents with the Federal Bureau of Investigation, Newark-Trenton Resident Agency under the direction of Special Assistant in Charge Stefanie Roddy; special agents with Homeland Security Investigations, Cherry Hill, under the direction of Acting Special Agent in Charge Spiros Karabinas; special agents with the Internal Revenue Service – Criminal Investigation, Newark Field Office, under the direction of Jenifer L. Piovesan; special agents with Treasury Inspector General for Tax Administration, Northeast Field Division, under the direction of Special Agent in Charge Michael Carpenter; special agents with the Defense Criminal Investigative Service, Northeast Field Office, under the direction of Acting Special Agent in Charge Jessica Herrington; special agents with the U.S. Air Force – Office of Special Investigations, Detachment 307, Joint Base McGuire-Dix-Lakehurst, New Jersey, under the

direction of Special Agent in Charge Rebecca B. Bates; and postal inspectors of the U.S. Postal Inspection Service, Philadelphia Division, under the direction of Inspector in Charge, Christopher Nielson, with the investigation leading to the guilty pleas.

On April 7, the Department of Justice announced the creation of the National Fraud Enforcement Division ("Fraud Division"). The Fraud Division is laser-focused on investigating and prosecuting those who commit fraud against the American people. The Department's work to combat fraud supports President Trump's Task Force to Eliminate Fraud, a whole-of-government effort chaired by Vice President J.D. Vance to eliminate fraud, waste, and abuse within Federal benefit programs.

The government is represented by Assistant U.S. Attorney Benjamin D. Bleiberg of the Economic Crimes Unit in Newark.

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Defense counsel:

Brown: Vincent J. LaPaglia, Esq.

Ebert: Maximillian Novel, Esq.

Graves-Carmichael: Kevin Buchan, Esq.

Hooper: Jacqueline E. Cistaro, Esq.

Kearse: William Strazza, Esq.

Lee: Terrell A. Ratliff, Esq.

Semmon: Tara Breslow-Testa, Esq.

Rouzard: Kathleen Theurer-Platts, Esq.